Living What Remains

A Practical Companion to The Song of What Remains and The Song of the Unbound

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Contents

Why a Practical Companion **3**

Part One: The Teaching in Plain Words **4**
1. What both songs actually claim . . . 4
2. What the songs do not claim . . . 4
3. The two songs as two tools . . . 5

Part Two: Practices You Can Do Anywhere **6**
Practice 1: The Turn (30 seconds) . . . 6
Practice 2: Not This (2 minutes) . . . 6
Practice 3: Name and Widen (1 minute, for strong emotions) . . . 6
Practice 4: The Doer Check (during any action) . . . 7
Practice 5: The One-Pocket Test (before any decision about others) . . . 7
Practice 6: The Small Death (5 minutes, evening) . . . 7
Practice 7: Silence Before Speech (3 seconds) . . . 8

Part Three: The Teaching in Each Area of Life **9**
1. Work and ambition . . . 9
2. Money, power, and envy . . . 9
3. Failure, rejection, and comparison . . . 10
4. Fear and anxiety . . . 10
5. Anger and conflict . . . 11
6. Family, friends, and love . . . 11
7. Study and learning . . . 11
8. Decisions and direction . . . 12
9. Grief, illness, and death . . . 12

Part Four: Common Traps **13**
Trap 1: Using it to avoid feelings . . . 13
Trap 2: Using it to excuse harm . . . 13
Trap 3: Passivity . . . 13
Trap 4: Spiritual pride . . . 13
Trap 5: Chasing special states . . . 13
Trap 6: Coldness . . . 13
Trap 7: Getting lost in concepts . . . 14

Part Five: A Thirty-Day Plan **15**

Week 1: Noticing awareness 15
Week 2: Feelings and fear 15
Week 3: Action, work, and money 15
Week 4: Non-separation and silence 15
How to know it is working 15

Part Six: When to Seek Outside Help **17**

Reference Card **18**

Why a Practical Companion

The two songs speak from the summit. *The Song of What Remains* walks a seeker up the mountain through dialogue. *The Song of the Unbound* is the voice of someone already standing at the top. Both were written in the spirit of two old works, the *Ashtavakra Gita* and the *Avadhuta Gita*, which are famous for refusing to give practical advice. They say, in effect: you are already free, so there is nothing to do.

That is true, and it is also useless on a Monday morning when you have an exam, an empty bank account, a fight with your family, and a heart pounding with fear.

This companion asks one plain question: **what difference does any of this make to how I live?**

The honest answer is a large difference, but not the one people expect. Self-realization does not make problems disappear. It changes who has them. A problem carried by a small, frightened, separate self feels like a matter of life and death. The same problem, held by open awareness, becomes a task: sometimes hard, sometimes painful, but workable.

The practical sense of both songs comes down to five shifts:

1. **From identity to awareness.** You stop living as a fragile story that has to be defended, and start living as the steady knowing in which every story appears.
2. **From control to participation.** You stop believing you personally author every result, and start acting fully while letting results come as they come.
3. **From scarcity to wholeness.** You stop trying to fill an inner hole with money, status, or approval, and start acting from a place that already lacks nothing.
4. **From separation to kinship.** You stop seeing others as rivals or tools, and start seeing them as the same life wearing another face.
5. **From resisting to allowing.** You stop fighting thoughts and feelings, and start letting them move through without being ruled by them.

None of these needs belief. Each one can be tested today, in a few minutes, in your own experience. The rest of this book shows how.

How to use this book:

- Part One sums up the teaching in plain words.
- Part Two gives short practices you can do anywhere.
- Part Three applies the teaching to specific areas of life.
- Part Four names the common traps.
- Part Five is a thirty-day plan.
- Part Six says when to seek outside help.
- At the end there is a one-page reference card.

Part One: The Teaching in Plain Words

1. What both songs actually claim

Remove the poetry, and both songs make the same few claims:

Claim one: you are not only what you think you are. You think you are a body with a name, a history, a set of talents and failures. All of these are real at their own level. But each of them is *known*. You are aware of your body, aware of your thoughts, aware of your history. Whatever is aware of these things is not one more item on the list.

(The Song of What Remains, chapters II–IV; The Song of the Unbound, chapter I.)

Claim two: that awareness is not damaged by what it knows. Shame, failure, rejection, and fear happen *in* awareness, the way storms happen in the sky. They are real experiences, but they do not stain or shrink the knowing itself.

(Unbound, chapter II, "Without Stain.")

Claim three: actions happen; the "doer" is mostly a story told afterward. When you look closely, decisions arise from causes you never chose: your genes, your upbringing, what you ate, what you read yesterday. The feeling "I did that" usually appears after the doing.

(What Remains, chapter IX; Unbound, chapter IV.)

Claim four: the separation between you and the world is thinner than it looks. In direct experience, there is no gap between seeing and what is seen. The world appears *in* your awareness, not outside it.

(What Remains, chapter XIV; Unbound, chapter VI.)

Claim five: freedom is not something you reach; it is what is left when you stop overlooking it. That is why both songs end in silence rather than in a reward.

2. What the songs do not claim

It is just as important to be clear about what is *not* being said.

- They do **not** say the world is fake and so nothing matters. They say the world is not separate from you, which makes it matter *more*.

- They do **not** say you should stop working, studying, or planning. They say you can do all of these without being crushed by them.
- They do **not** say feelings are bad or should be suppressed. They say feelings can be fully felt without being obeyed.
- They do **not** say you are not responsible for your actions. Your body and mind still answer for what they do in the world.
- They do **not** promise permanent bliss. They point to a stability that holds pain as well as joy.

3. The two songs as two tools

The two texts have different practical uses.

The Song of What Remains (the dialogue) is a tool for inquiry. Use it when you are confused, stuck, or doubting. The seeker's questions are your questions. Read one chapter slowly, and after each answer from the teacher, stop and check it against your own experience.

The Song of the Unbound (the monologue) is a tool for remembering. Use it when you already understand but have forgotten in the rush of the day. Its first-person "I am" lines can be read aloud, not as statements about a person named Bagus or anyone else, but as statements about awareness itself. Read this way, they reset the mind the way cold water resets a tired face.

A simple rule: **when you doubt, read the dialogue; when you forget, read the monologue.**

Part Two: Practices You Can Do Anywhere

These practices are short on purpose. None needs a cushion, a special room, or more than a few minutes. Each one turns one line of the songs into something you can test.

Practice 1: The Turn (30 seconds)

Purpose: to notice awareness directly.

1. Notice something you can see: a cup, a wall, a screen.
2. Notice that you are aware of it.
3. Now, instead of looking at the object, gently turn attention toward the awareness itself. Ask: "What is aware right now?"
4. Do not answer with a thought. Just notice what happens. Usually there is a moment of open, quiet clarity with no object in it.
5. Rest there for a few breaths, then go back to what you were doing.

Do this ten times a day: before opening your phone, before a meal, before replying to a message. Small and often beats long and rare.

(What Remains IV, "The Witness"; Unbound I, "What Is Left.")

Practice 2: Not This (2 minutes)

Purpose: to loosen identification with body and thought.

1. Sit or stand quietly.
2. Notice a body sensation, such as pressure in your feet. Say silently: "This is known. I am the knowing of it."
3. Notice a thought. Say silently: "This is known. I am the knowing of it."
4. Notice a feeling, such as tension or calm. Say silently: "This is known. I am the knowing of it."
5. Finally, try to find the knower as an object. You will not find it. Stay with the not-finding. It is not empty; it is awake.

Practice 3: Name and Widen (1 minute, for strong emotions)

Purpose: to feel emotions fully without being ruled by them.

1. When a strong feeling arrives, name it in one word: “fear,” “anger,” “shame,” “envy.”
2. Find where it lives in the body: chest, throat, stomach, jaw.
3. Breathe into that place and let it be exactly as strong as it is. Do not fight it, and do not feed it with stories.
4. Now widen your attention to include the room, the sounds, the whole field of experience. Notice that the feeling is one part of a much larger space.
5. Ask: “Is the space that holds this feeling disturbed by it?”

This is the practical meaning of “feelings are weather; I am the sky.”

(Unbound VIII, “On Thought and Feeling.”)

Practice 4: The Doer Check (during any action)

Purpose: to act fully without carrying the weight of control.

While doing anything, such as writing code, washing dishes, or walking, ask once: “Is there a separate ‘me’ doing this, or is it just happening?”

Look honestly. You may find that typing happens, walking happens, thoughts about the next step happen. The sense of a central controller is much weaker than you assumed.

The point is **not** to stop acting. Action usually becomes smoother and more focused when the controller relaxes. Athletes and musicians call this flow.

(What Remains IX; Unbound IV.)

Practice 5: The One-Pocket Test (before any decision about others)

Purpose: to act ethically from understanding rather than from rules.

Before a decision that affects someone else, especially about money, power, or truth, ask:

> “If there were only one pocket in the universe, would this still make sense?”

Taking from another person is taking from the whole you belong to. Lying to another person creates a split inside the one field of awareness. This is not a commandment; it is a way of seeing.

(Unbound X, “Wealth and Power.”)

Practice 6: The Small Death (5 minutes, evening)

Purpose: to practice letting go before you are forced to.

1. At the end of the day, lie down.
2. Recall the day briefly: its wins, losses, embarrassments.
3. Say silently: “This day is finished. I let it go.”
4. Imagine the person you were today dissolving, the way each earlier version of you dissolved: the child, the student who failed an exam, the one who was once afraid.
5. Notice what remains when the day is gone. Fall asleep resting there.

(What Remains VII, “On Fear and Death”; Unbound V, “Unborn.”)

Practice 7: Silence Before Speech (3 seconds)

Purpose: to answer rather than react.

Before replying in any tense conversation, take one breath and notice the silence that the other person's words appeared in. Then speak from that silence.

Three seconds is enough. It is the difference between a reaction and a response.

(What Remains XVIII, "Silence.")

Part Three: The Teaching in Each Area of Life

1. Work and ambition

The common problem: You tie your worth to your results. Success makes you inflated; failure makes you collapse. Either way, you are anxious, because your identity is on the line every day.

What the songs offer: Your worth is not on the line, because what you fundamentally are cannot be added to or taken away. That frees you to take *bigger* risks, not smaller ones. You can start the company, apply to the program, or pitch the investor, because rejection hurts the story but not the self.

In practice:

- Set goals boldly, and hold them lightly. Effort is yours; results belong to many causes.
- Before an important task, do the Turn. Then work as if the work matters completely, because to the world it does.
- After a result, good or bad, ask: "What can be learned?" not "What does this say about me?"
- Measure yourself by the quality of your attention and effort, which you influence, more than by outcomes, which you do not control.

A test: if you would still do the work even if no one ever praised you for it, you are working from wholeness. If not, notice the hunger, without judging it.

(What Remains IX; Unbound IV and XII.)

2. Money, power, and envy

The common problem: You see others with wealth or authority, even dishonest wealth, and feel small. A voice says: "If I had that, I would finally be safe and respected."

What the songs offer: That voice is the separate self looking for a mountain big enough to fill an inner hole. No mountain is ever enough. People who steal and abuse power are, in the words of the monologue, "looking for me in the wrong place." Their fall is not just bad luck; it is what happens when you try to feed a hunger that cannot be fed from outside.

In practice:

- When envy arises, use Name and Widen. Envy is information: it tells you what you think you lack. Ask whether you actually lack it, or whether you lack the *feeling* you imagine it would

bring.
- Pursue money honestly and with energy. Build something useful. The songs do not ask you to be poor; they ask you not to confuse your bank balance with your being.
- Use the One-Pocket Test on every deal. Gains that require harming others are losses in disguise.
- Hold power the way you would hold a sharp knife: firmly enough to use, lightly enough to put down.

(Unbound X; What Remains VIII.)

3. Failure, rejection, and comparison

The common problem: A rejected application, a failed competition, or a friend who did better feels like proof that you are not enough.

What the songs offer: Every failure is an experience appearing in awareness. It is real, it can hurt, and it can teach. But it is not a verdict on what you are. You have already "died" many times: the version of you who expected to win died, and you are still here.

In practice:

- Allow the disappointment fully, for a set time if needed: one evening of sadness is honest.
- Then do the Small Death practice for that version of yourself.
- Write down three concrete lessons and one next action.
- When comparing yourself with others, remember: "There are no others, and there is no tall." Comparison measures shadows against shadows.

(Unbound II and V; What Remains XIII, "When Doubt Returns.")

4. Fear and anxiety

The common problem: The mind runs future disasters on repeat: failing, being poor, being humiliated, dying.

What the songs offer: Fear is a whisper that says "you are small, you will be crushed." The practical response is not to argue with it but to investigate: who is small? Where is the edge of me?

In practice:

- Notice that every fearful scenario is a thought happening *now*. The disaster is imagined; the thought is real.
- Separate fear into two kinds. **Useful fear** points to a real action, such as studying or saving money; take the action. **Useless fear** points to nothing you can do; use Name and Widen and let it pass.
- Return to the senses: three things you can see, two you can hear, one you can feel. The present moment almost never contains the disaster the mind predicts.

Important: If anxiety is constant, disturbs sleep for weeks, or comes in panic attacks, see Part Six. Insight and treatment work together.

(What Remains VII; Unbound VIII.)

5. Anger and conflict

The common problem: Someone insults or wrongs you, and you either explode or swallow it and grow bitter.

What the songs offer: Anger is a brush fire. Let it burn through without harming anyone, and the field turns green again. The person who wronged you is acting from their own hunger to be whole, the same hunger that once moved you. This does not make their action acceptable; it makes hatred unnecessary.

In practice:

- Use Silence Before Speech.
- Separate the action from the person. You can say a firm "no," set a boundary, or report wrongdoing, all without hatred.
- Ask: "What does this situation need?" rather than "How do I win?"
- Afterward, check: did I protect what needed protecting, and did I harm more than necessary?

(Unbound IX, "Among People"; What Remains XI, "On Others and On Love.")

6. Family, friends, and love

The common problem: Love gets mixed with need, control, and fear of loss.

What the songs offer: If awareness is shared, love is not a transaction between two separate beings; it is recognition of yourself in another. That kind of love can let people be who they are.

In practice:

- When a friend is hurting, do not lecture them about illusion. Listen and hold them. "That is the whole teaching."
- Honor your parents and siblings as real people with their own fears, while not letting their fears decide your path.
- Notice when you want something from someone, such as approval or agreement. Ask whether you can give that to yourself first.
- Practice seeing the same light in a stranger's eyes as in your own, for one second, a few times a day.

(Unbound IX; What Remains XI.)

7. Study and learning

The common problem: Learning becomes a race, and the mind treats every test as a threat.

What the songs offer: Curiosity is natural to awareness. When the fear of failing falls away, attention becomes wide and quick.

In practice:

- Start each study session with the Turn.
- Work in focused blocks, about 25 to 50 minutes, using the Doer Check to stay absorbed.
- When you are confused, notice the confusion as an experience rather than proof that you are stupid. Confusion is the feeling of the mind growing.

- Read the old books, and these two songs too, as maps, not as the territory. "The books were maps of a country I had been standing in the whole time."

8. Decisions and direction

The common problem: Big choices, such as career, university, or which business to build, feel paralyzing because the separate self fears choosing wrong.

What the songs offer: No single choice can damage what you are. That frees you to choose with a clear head, and to change course when new information appears.

In practice:

1. Write the options down.
2. For each, ask three questions:
   - Does this come from wholeness, or from fear and envy?
   - Does it pass the One-Pocket Test?
   - When I imagine doing it for a year, does energy rise or drain?
3. Sit in silence for five minutes. Notice which option feels quietly *right*, not exciting or safe.
4. Choose, act, and review after a set time.

A decision made from silence can still be wrong. But it will be easier to correct, because you will not have tied your identity to it.

9. Grief, illness, and death

The common problem: Loss shakes everything.

What the songs offer: Every form passes; the knowing in which forms appear does not seem to begin or end. This is a comfort, but it is never an excuse to skip grief.

In practice:

- Let grief be grief. Weep. "I do not tell it, 'You are an illusion.' I let it weep, and I hold the weeping."
- Remember that love does not need the form to continue in order to be real.
- In illness, care for the body fully: rest, eat, follow medical advice. The body is not you, and it is still yours to look after.

(What Remains VII; Unbound V and VIII.)

Part Four: Common Traps

Non-dual teaching is powerful, and powerful things can be misused. These are the most common ways people go wrong.

Trap 1: Using it to avoid feelings

Saying "it's all illusion" to escape sadness, anger, or trauma is not freedom; it is suppression dressed up in spiritual words. **The fix:** feel first, then widen. Never skip the feeling.

Trap 2: Using it to excuse harm

"There is no doer, so I am not responsible." This is the most dangerous misreading. The body-mind is still accountable in the world. **The fix:** remember that true seeing makes you *more* careful with others, because there is only one pocket.

Trap 3: Passivity

"Everything happens by itself, so why bother?" Action is part of what happens. Laziness is also a story, just a comfortable one. **The fix:** act fully, and hold the results lightly.

Trap 4: Spiritual pride

"I am awake and others are asleep." This is the dream wearing the crown of waking. **The fix:** the awake do the dishes. Ordinariness is the sign.

Trap 5: Chasing special states

Moments of bliss or emptiness may come. Trying to repeat them turns freedom into another goal. **The fix:** look for what does not change, not for what feels amazing.

Trap 6: Coldness

Some people use detachment as a wall. **The fix:** non-separation should make the heart warmer, "unbearably warm." If you are becoming colder, you have misunderstood.

Trap 7: Getting lost in concepts

Endless reading and debating about awareness can replace looking at awareness. **The fix:** for every hour of reading, spend at least a few minutes in direct practice.

Part Five: A Thirty-Day Plan

This plan uses about 15 to 20 minutes a day. It is a starting structure, not a rule.

Week 1: Noticing awareness

- **Daily:** the Turn, ten times; Not This, once.
- **Reading:** *The Song of What Remains*, chapters I–V (about one per day, then a rest day).
- **Evening:** write one sentence: "Today I noticed awareness when. . . "

Week 2: Feelings and fear

- **Daily:** the Turn, ten times; Name and Widen for every strong feeling.
- **Reading:** *What Remains*, chapters VI–X, and *The Song of the Unbound*, chapter VIII.
- **Evening:** the Small Death practice.
- **Journal:** which feeling showed up most, and what happened when you widened around it?

Week 3: Action, work, and money

- **Daily:** the Doer Check during work or study; the One-Pocket Test before any decision involving others.
- **Reading:** *What Remains*, chapters XI–XIII, and *Unbound*, chapters IV and X.
- **Weekly task:** make one honest, useful effort toward a goal without checking the result for 48 hours.
- **Journal:** where did you work from wholeness, and where from fear or envy?

Week 4: Non-separation and silence

- **Daily:** Silence Before Speech in every conversation; the Turn, ten times.
- **Reading:** *What Remains*, chapters XIV–XVIII, and *Unbound*, chapters VI, IX, and XII.
- **Weekly task:** do one kind act for someone who cannot repay you, without telling anyone.
- **Day 30:** sit for twenty minutes in silence. Then write one page: what has changed, what has not, and what you want to keep.

How to know it is working

Look for these signs, not for visions or bliss:

- You recover from setbacks faster.
- You react less and respond more.
- You feel less need to prove yourself.
- You can sit with discomfort without running to your phone.
- You feel more kindness toward people who irritate you.
- You still act, plan, and build, but with less strain.

Part Six: When to Seek Outside Help

Self-inquiry is not a replacement for medical or mental-health care. Seek help from a doctor, psychologist, or counselor if any of these happen:

- You feel persistently unreal, detached from your body, or as if the world is fake in a frightening way. This is a known condition called depersonalization or derealization, and it is different from peaceful clarity.
- Low mood, hopelessness, or loss of interest lasts more than two weeks.
- Anxiety or panic disrupts sleep, eating, or daily functioning.
- You have thoughts of harming yourself or others. In that case, contact someone you trust and local emergency services immediately.
- Old trauma surfaces strongly during practice.

In that case, pause the inquiry practices and keep only the gentle ones, such as returning to the senses, until you have support. Real insight is never fragile; it will still be there when you are ready.

Reference Card

The five shifts

1. Identity → awareness
2. Control → participation
3. Scarcity → wholeness
4. Separation → kinship
5. Resisting → allowing

The seven practices

Practice	When	Time
The Turn	Ten times a day	30 seconds
Not This	Once a day	2 minutes
Name and Widen	Any strong feeling	1 minute
Doer Check	During work	One question
One-Pocket Test	Before decisions about others	One question
Small Death	Evening	5 minutes
Silence Before Speech	Tense conversations	3 seconds

Which song to read

- When you doubt: *The Song of What Remains* (dialogue).
- When you forget: *The Song of the Unbound* (monologue).

Three questions to carry

- What is aware right now?
- Is this coming from wholeness, or from fear?
- If there were only one pocket, would this still make sense?

One line to remember

Act fully. Hold results lightly. Feel everything. Harm no one. Rest as what knows.